

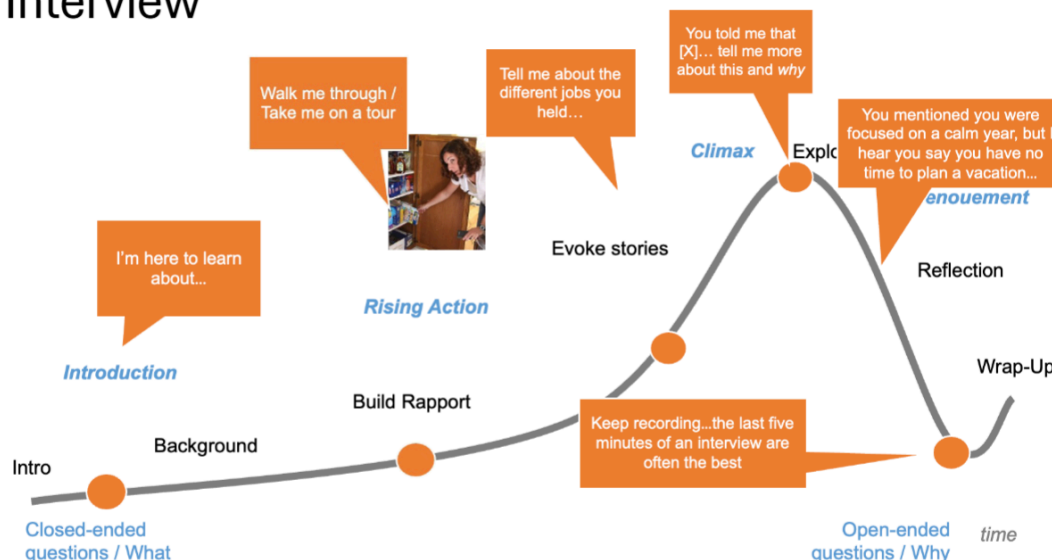
Skye Carbin - I have difficulty distinguishing the direction that loud sounds originate from.

Interview:

- Can you walk us through a typical day in your life?
- We learned that you are a Research Administrator/Coordinator at MetroHealth, could you tell us more about what you do, as you feel comfortable sharing?
- Can you share the first experience where you found it challenging to identify the sources of loud sounds?
- Are there any types of sounds you find more difficult to distinguish than others?
- Are there any sounds you would specifically like to be able to identify more?
- How often do you find yourself struggling to locate a loud sound, and what sorts of consequences has this had on your day-to-day life?
- Are there any solutions you have tried in the past to help mitigate this problem? How well did they work, if at all, and why do you think that is?

Sample outline from the slides:

Interview



Martin's Notes:

[3:20] Interview start, introductions

[3:21] Day through life: workday

- research coordinator, basic sciences & rehab
- administrative, coordinator
- "People person for people who are not people persons"

[3:22] Skye is deaf in one ear, partially deaf in other

- Hampers comm. director role
- Everyday situations
- safety concern (driving)

[3:23] Particular sounds?

- "sensorineural hearing loss"
- Brain can't process noise
- Many sources of noise
- Have to focus on one sound at a time
- very low or very high frequencies

[3:25] Situations that are easier to parse sounds?

- Easy when there's only one source of sound
- has to turn her head to hear sounds better

[3:27] methods of mitigation?

- virtual meetings very useful
- visual methods are the most effective
- audio cues are hardest

[3:29] how do you respond to tactile feedback?

- smart watch vibrations useful

[3:30] Scenario where this caused

- team meetings
- circular formation
- useful teammates
 - a lot to ask of others
 - "hate having to have secondhand versions of what someone said"
 - not appropriate to ask for clarification
 - "I want to be as independent as possible"

[3:32] What do other people do to make it easier for you?

- Chairs disability organizations
- teammates do things to help
 - turn towards Skye for lip reading
 - tap & point to who's talking

[3:33] Situations outside workplace?

- watching movie, have to pause to hear friends talking
- bars are very loud
- walking around in the city
- COVID-19, masking made hearing more difficult

[3:36] hearing aid, what kind?

- bluetooth hearing aid, four years old, due for replacement

[3:37] difficulty processing?

- hearing aid helps with volume, but not processing
- has times where she turns hearing aid down
- "My ear doesn't have the problem, it's my brain"
- Great for degenerative hearing loss, only solution for Skye's specific form of hearing loss

[3:40] technological visual aids?

- organic visual aids tend to come up more
- "A helpful design for everyone"
- Nothing technology-wise for Skye's specific hearing loss

- localize where she should be focusing

- Ideal case scenario: small lapel that lights up directions

[3:43] previous jobs in the past where people were not aware of disability

- retail jobs
 - some people not hospitable
- ulta
 - many different senses, music, fragrances, people talking

[3:46] reach out if have more questions

[3:46] interview end

Skye personality:

- "charismatic introvert"
- resilient person

Meeting Notes

Interviewee Background

- Background in mathematics
- Works as a Coordinator at MetroHealth
- Provides administrative and staffing support for research institutes and researchers
- Supports the CTSC program and coordinates research-related activities

Hearing and hearing aid

- Deaf in one ear and has partial hearing loss in the other ear.
- Has sensorineural hearing loss, involving processing difficulties
- Uses an Oticon hearing aid and has used it for approximately four years; plans to replace it soon
- Relies significantly on lip reading
- Tends to orient herself toward the side with partial hearing

Challenges

- The greatest difficulty is determining where a sound is coming from and where to focus her attention
- Environments containing multiple sounds are challenging
- Having people speak louder does not help and can sometimes make it more difficult
- Certain high and low frequency sounds can be difficult to process
- Unfamiliar/ sounds can be especially difficult to identify
- Communication is much easier when only one person is speaking because there is only one sound source to focus on

Safety Concerns

- Difficulty determining sound direction can create safety issues while driving.
- For example, she may hear a car horn but be unable to determine which direction the horn came from
- Being able to rapidly identify where she needs to direct her attention is important in these situations.

Work & Social Impact

- Leading in-person meetings can be difficult, especially when multiple people speak simultaneously
- It can be overwhelming to quiet a group
- Prefers to remain as independent as possible rather than relying on others for assistance
- Group environments such as bars are challenging

- Watching movies with friends can become difficult when people talk while the movie is playing because there are multiple competing sound sources
- COVID-19 masks created significant communication difficulties because they prevented her from lip reading
- Has experienced situations in retail and other workplaces where people can become frustrated or may not be accommodating of her hearing difficulties

Current Accommodations & Strategies

- Prefers online/video meetings when possible.
 - Video platforms make it easier to identify who is currently speaking through visual speaker indicators
- Uses headphones, which help focus the sound
- Relies heavily on visual indicators
- Uses a smartwatch for notifications
- Uses Bluetooth technology with her hearing aid

Limitations of Current Hearing Aid

- The hearing aid primarily amplifies sound rather than solving the processing problem
- Described it as more of a “band-aid” than a solution
- Hearing aid can sometimes make things worse when there are many sounds occurring simultaneously
- She sometimes turns the hearing aid volume down because it is not always helpful
- The hearing aid is not specifically designed around her particular hearing loss
- More advanced technology may also present an insurance issue.